

Cleaner air, already?

ERA's statement that its Air Quality Plan's measures have already worked, tested against station data

THE CLAIM

“The plan outlines actions that have already yielded positive results for Malta’s air quality...”

Environment and Resources Authority, Air Quality Plan for Malta 2025 web page, 12 March 2025

The plan names six: power-sector reform, transport grants, free school transport, ferries, free public transport.

Tested with 13 years of validated EEA data and ERA's own reports.

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

Power reform shown to help; transport measures not shown.

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

–99.9%

Power-station sulphur cut

Sulphur oxides from power stations, 2008 to 2018; SO₂ in the air fell 82% at Żejtun.

–22%

NO₂ at Msida

2015–17 to 2021–23, in step with a cleaner fleet; not tied to any named measure.

52 days

PM10 limit broken, 2023

At Msida after ERA deducts dust and sea salt; 35 allowed. Worst of 2015–2025.

+8.1

After free transport

µg/m³ PM10 at Msida, year after Oct 2022 vs year before; 10 of 11 readings rose.

4 of 6

No air data offered

Grants, ferry landings, fast ferry, free transport: uptake or passengers only.

FAIR TO SAY

ERA states the 2018 and 2023 breaches itself, and the plan says traffic growth offset gains. Flat PM10 does not prove the measures did nothing.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ The study behind “already yielded”.

☐ Data for the school-transport figures.

☐ Traffic counts near Msida, 2018–23.

☐ Sources of the 2023 PM10 excess.